

The China Syndrome: Local Labor Market Effects of Import Competition in the United States

David H. Autor (MIT) · David Dorn (University of Zurich) · Gordon H. Hanson (UCSD)

American Economic Review, 2013, Vol. 103, No. 6, pp. 2121–2168 DOI: 10.1257/aer.103.6.2121

Abstract / Résumé / 要旨

This paper analyzes the effect of rising Chinese import competition between 1990 and 2007 on U.S. local labor markets. The authors exploit variation across local labor markets in import exposure stemming from initial differences in industry specialization and instrument for U.S. imports using changes in Chinese imports by other high-income countries. Rising exposure to Chinese imports leads to higher unemployment, lower labor force participation, and reduced wages in local labor markets that house import-competing manufacturing industries. Transfer payments in the form of unemployment insurance, disability benefits, and retirement benefits rise, and these increases are not offset by changes in other transfer programs. The study estimates that import competition from China explains about one-quarter of the contemporaneous aggregate decline in U.S. manufacturing employment. The findings highlight the significant adjustment costs associated with trade liberalization.

Keywords / Mots-clés / キーワード

trade shocks; import competition; local labor markets; China; manufacturing employment; United States

Source / Source / 出典

Autor, D.H., Dorn, D., & Hanson, G.H. (2013). American Economic Review, 103(6), 2121–2168.

Generated: 2026-06-30 | This is a bibliographic reference sheet